THE RETURN OF COVID?



MANISH RAJPUT

LOOMING THREAT
A person getting tested for Covid-19

By Sonali Acharjee

Just over two months ago, on January 17, India had logged the lowest-ever number of daily Covid-19 infections since the beginning of the pandemic in March 2020. For many, this signalled the end of the pandemic after three long, challenging years. That precious end, however, now seems debatable, with the virus again sweeping through India on the back of a new variant: the XBB.1.16, of which the country has recorded over 600 cases so far. The total Covid-19 caseload has risen sharply: on March 29, India saw a single-day rise of 2,151 cases, the highest in five months. Active cases on the same day stood at 11,903, the highest in over four months. The average daily cases recorded in the week ending March 23 was 966, thrice the daily average of 313 seen in the week ending March 3. More worryingly, in the week ending March 27, as many as 44 districts across 18 states and UTs had a weekly test positivity rate (TPR) of 10 per cent or more, double the World Health Organization's (WHO) prescribed limit of 5 per cent. Also, there were 72 districts across 16 states and UTs where the TPR was 5-10 per cent, up from 15 (across eight states) around two weeks ago. The figures have sent alarm bells ringing across the country .

"There is no room for complacency. We are closely assessing the situation and are vigilant," says N.K. Arora, chairman of the Indian SARS-CoV-2 Genomics Consortium (INSACOG). On March 27, the Centre also held a meeting with states to review preparedness and asked authorities to focus on increasing genomic surveillance and testing, as well as on ensuring that there are enough beds in hospitals should India see a massive wave again.

But, there's reason to be optimistic. Though the XBB.1.16, a recombinant of Omicron's BA.2.10.1 and BA.2.75 sub-variants, is highly contagious—the total number of XBB.1.16 cases reported by INSACOG rose from 349 on March 23 to 610 in less than a week—most infections, so far, have been manageable. Also, while the XBB, and another sub-variant, the XBB 1.5, which have been around since October last year, caused massive surges in the US, Singapore and Europe, they didn't have a major impact on the Indian population. There's a reason for it. "Indians have hybrid immunity, which is very effective," says noted virologist Dr Gagandeep Kang. "We have naturally-acquired immunity gained through infection in the past, as well as vaccine immunity. Small variations in daily numbers is not something to be alarmed by," she says.

WHAT THE NUMBERS SAY

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- **Active cases as of March 29 stood at 11,903, the highest in over four months**
- **As of March 27, as many as 44 districts in 18 states and UTs had a weekly test positivity rate of 10 per cent or more, higher than the WHO-prescribed limit of 5 per cent**